

1. THE FUN THEY HAD

Margie even wrote about it that night in her diary. On the page headed 17 May 2157, she wrote, "Today Tommy found a real book!"

It was a very old book. Margie's grandfather once said that when he was a little boy his grandfather told him that there was a time when all stories were printed on paper.

They turned the pages, which were yellow and crinkly, and it was awfully funny to read words that stood still instead of moving the way they were supposed to on a screen, you know. And then, when they turned back to the page before, it had the same words on it that it had had when they read it the first time.

"Gee," said Tommy, "what a waste. When you're through with the book, you just throw it away, I guess. Our television screen must have had a million books on it and it's good for plenty more. I wouldn't throw it away."

"Same with mine," said Margie. She was eleven and hadn't seen as many telebooks as Tommy had. He was thirteen.

She said, "Where did you find it?"

"In my house." He pointed without looking, because he was busy reading. "In the attic."

"What's it about?"

"School."

Margie was scornful. "School? What's there to write about school? I hate school." Margie always hated school, but now she hated it more than ever. The mechanical teacher had been giving her test after test in geography and she had been doing worse and worse until her mother had shaken her head sorrowfully and sent for the county inspector.

He was a round little man with a red face and a whole box of tools with dials and wires. He smiled at her and gave her an apple, then took the teacher apart. Margie had hoped he wouldn't know how to put it together again, but he knew how all right and, after an hour or so, there it was again, large and black and ugly with a big screen on which all the lessons were shown and the questions were asked.

2. THE SOUND OF MUSIC

Part I: Evelyn Glennie Listens to Sound without Hearing It

Evelyn Glennie was determined to lead a normal life, in spite of being profoundly deaf. At the age of eleven, Evelyn Glennie made up her mind that she wanted to be a musician. Her teacher, Ron Forbes, told her to feel the note of A and to feel the sound through her body. She learnt to open her mind and body to the sounds around her.

Evelyn was just eight years old when she first became aware that she was losing her hearing. By the age of eleven she was profoundly deaf. But this did not prevent her from pursuing her ambition.

When Evelyn was about to start secondary school, her mother was informed by the school doctor that she was profoundly deaf and that her employment perspectives were very poor. Her parents and teachers at the Royal Academy of Music in London disagreed. She was allowed to join.

She worked with a percussionist, Ron Forbes, who opened up a new world for her. He banged a large drum twice and told her to listen with her hands rather than her ears. He told Evelyn to feel the vibrations in her body. After a while, Evelyn began to detect the change in pitch.

The nerve of hearing in her ear had been damaged beyond repair. Most people would have given up, but Evelyn was determined. She practised hard and won a scholarship to the Royal Academy of Music. Today she is a world-famous musician.

Part II: The Shehnai of Bismillah Khan

The sound of the shehnai is considered auspicious and is associated with all good things in life. Ustad Bismillah Khan is credited with taking this instrument beyond the threshold of the traditional performance spaces.

The shehnai is a wind musical instrument. It is made of wood and has a double reed at the top from which air is blown. Its lower end opens out into a funnel shape. There are between six and nine holes on its body. The shehnai was traditionally played in temples and on auspicious occasions like royal processions and weddings.

3. THE LITTLE GIRL

To the little girl he was a figure to be feared and avoided. Every morning before going to work her father came into her room and gave her a casual kiss, to which she responded with 'Goodbye, Father'. And oh, there was a glad sense of relief when she heard the gate bang behind the tall, stiff figure!

And then one day she saw something remarkable. She saw that her father was just an ordinary man. Not a god, not a monster, but a man who worked hard and was tired. It changed everything.

Kezia was the daughter. She was afraid of her father. She would stay in the drawing room, well away from the study where her father worked in the evenings. She would tiptoe and speak softly whenever she was made to go near his study.

One day she was asked to make a pin cushion for her father's birthday. Searching for stuffing she found her father's important speech papers and used them as stuffing. She was beaten for this mistake.

But during a terrible nightmare, it was her father who held her safely and gently. She realized then that her father loved her dearly. She snuggled against his warm chest, and her fear melted away.

4. A TRULY BEAUTIFUL MIND

Albert Einstein was born on 14 March 1879 in Ulm, Germany. He was slow to learn to speak as a child. His mother worried that something was wrong with him. But Einstein's grandmother thought he was thoroughly lovable, and his mother was hopeful that nothing was wrong.

Albert's playmates thought he was boring. He preferred to play cards alone. His sister, Maja, said he used to build card houses that stood up to fourteen storeys.

In school, Albert hated the mechanical learning and memorization. He rebelled against the German way of teaching. He was extraordinarily curious about science. At the age of twelve he taught himself algebra and Euclidean geometry over a single summer.

At fifteen, his father's business failed and the family moved to Milan, Italy. Albert stayed back and finished his schooling in Switzerland. In 1900, he graduated from Zurich Polytechnic, but could not find a job for two years.

In 1902, he got a job at the Patent Office in Berne. In 1905, while still working there, he published three scientific papers that changed our understanding of nature. His Special Theory of Relativity introduced the most famous equation in physics: $E=mc^2$.

Albert Einstein won the Nobel Prize in Physics in 1921. He was also a campaigner for peace. He wrote a letter to Franklin D. Roosevelt urging the United States not to use atomic weapons. His message was: peace is more important than any political objective.

5. THE SNAKE AND THE MIRROR

The doctor recalled the incident. He was a young doctor at the time. He had a poor practice and lived in a small rented room. The room was small, dirty and smelly. In the night, the rats used to have a field day. There was no electricity.

One night, the doctor lit a kerosene lamp and sat down to read a book. He had had his supper. The room was very hot. He was reading a medical book. The sound of a rat or some other small animal could be heard now and then.

Suddenly the lamp began to flicker. He looked up and saw a fat snake crawling out from a hole in the wall. The snake slithered along the floor and then coiled itself on the arm of the chair where the doctor sat. The snake then raised its head and looked at the mirror, as if it were a wonderful thing to look at itself.

The doctor sat still. Cold sweat poured down. He was very afraid. Then he had an idea. He slowly stood up and walked out of the room without making a noise. He ran to his friend's house and told him everything.

When they came back, the snake had gone. The wife of his friend, a jealous woman, had left her husband's house that night. The snake had coiled itself around her arm as she was dressing to go out. She ran away screaming, and the snake also disappeared.